

# REVOLUTIONS and rights

## LIFE IN THE MUSLIM WORLD

### ▼ Toppling a tyrant

Egyptian women and girls gather at Cairo's Tahrir Square on February 6, 2011, calling for the removal of dictator President Hosni Mubarak.

Throughout the 20th century, there were dramatic transformations in many Muslim-majority nations, particularly in the Middle East and Pakistan. Conflicts between extremist and liberal groups were rife, and political turmoil led to great upheaval, with mixed consequences for Muslim women.

Towards the end of the 20th century, women took part in a number of revolutions in the Middle East. For example, large numbers of women actively participated in the Iranian Revolution in 1979, which overthrew the monarchy to create an Islamic republic. Unfortunately, many of those involved found their rights diminished after the revolution. The new regime sought to stamp out Western influences on women's dress, enforcing full cover in public, and laws were introduced which were designed to drive women out of the workplace. Women also suffered due to the economic consequences of war. The devastation caused by the Gulf War in Iraq (1990–1991) meant that more girls were pulled out of school to support their families, and were later unable to enter the workforce.

Revolutions did not, however, have a universally negative impact for women in the Muslim world. Although in some locations the uprisings of the Arab Spring (2010–2012) resulted in an increase in violence against women, in Tunisia the number of women in government increased and there have been gains in women's rights there, too. In addition, a host of strong female Muslim voices emerged at the end of the 20th century, notably Benazir Bhutto, the first female prime minister of a majority-Muslim country. During her time in office (1988–1990 and 1993–1996), Bhutto advocated for better women's education and employment, and spoke against misogynistic interpretations of Islam. She faced great resistance, and was ultimately assassinated in 2007, likely by the Pakistani Taliban.

### Muslim women's rights

More recently, there have been breakthroughs in women's rights in several Muslim countries. For example, in 2015, women in Saudi Arabia were granted the vote (66 years after women in Syria, the first Middle Eastern country to enfranchise women), and in 2018, Saudi women were allowed to drive for the first time. Still, Saudi women, and women in other Muslim countries, continue to face injustices. Weeks before the driving ban was lifted, many high-profile women's rights advocates, who had been campaigning for the end to Saudi Arabia's male guardianship system as well as for the right to drive, were arrested. Under the guardianship system, which applies in several Muslim countries, women cannot travel abroad, marry, or do many other things without the permission of a male relative. In some Muslim nations women are also abused for not covering their bodies sufficiently. In Pakistan, for example, acid attacks have been made on unveiled women by extremists.

